



A WORKER at the Wayuu rose farm harvests flowers in Guasca, Colombia. The Hearts variety grows only in Colombia and Ecuador.

Photographs by IVAN VALENCIA For The Times

COLUMN ONE

A rose’s journey from farm to float

Bob Mellano has stressful job of bringing the Hearts variety from Colombia to the annual Pasadena parade

By THOMAS CURWEN

A little more than a week before the 136th Tournament of Roses Parade, Bob Mellano was counting flowers and coming up short — 50,000 roses short.

Mellano studied his paperwork. A flower wholesaler in downtown Los Angeles, he can spot discrepancies from a distance.

The night before, two trucks from Miami had pulled up to his loading dock with dozens of pallets stacked with flower boxes. By the time his crew offloaded them, he could see that he was at least 250 boxes short — and that included the roses he especially needed, an award-winning variety known as Hearts.

Mellano, 62, concealed his worry behind years of experience. Within a week, the floats would be ready for their flowers, and making up the difference would not be easy or cheap.

From his office on the second floor of the downtown [See Rose, A7]



THE HEARTS ROSE, with its complex bloom, often plays the lead on many Rose Parade entries. A single float sometimes uses thousands of them.

Illegal border entries decline sharply

Unlawful crossings from Mexico hit a four-year low in November, U.S. authorities say.

By SALVADOR HERNANDEZ AND RUBEN VIVES

Unlawful crossings along the U.S.-Mexico border have dropped to a four-year low, according to U.S. Customs and Border Protection, with 46,610 people stopped between ports of entry in November.

The number of illegal crossings that month marked an 18% decrease from the previous month, and the lowest level since July 2020, the agency said.

“Our enhanced enforcement efforts, combined with executive actions and coordination with Mexico and Central American countries in recent months, are having a sustained, meaningful impact,” said Troy A. Miller, the acting head of U.S. Customs and Border Protection.

From June through November, the Department of Homeland Security removed more than 240,000 people, according to the agency. In fiscal year 2024, the department also removed more than 700,000 from the country, more than any prior year since 2010.

The numbers represent something of a turnaround for the Biden administration, which faced major political backlash for a surge in illegal crossings earlier in President Biden’s term. President-elect Donald Trump slammed Biden and Vice President Kamala Harris for the increases.

Immigration experts attribute the drop in border encounters — people stopped trying to cross between ports of entry — to multiple factors, including what they said is the current administration’s “carrot-and-stick” approach.

Under the Biden administration, officials have en- [See Border, A5]



BSIP/Universal Images Group

ABOUT half of dietary lead exposure for children under age 1 comes from packaged baby foods, and an additional 36% from infant formula, a USDA study found.

New state law requires baby food labels to show 4 heavy metals levels

By JENNY GOLD

Beginning Wednesday, baby food makers that sell products in California will have to make a major shift toward transparency and provide a QR code on their packaging that takes consumers to test results for the

presence in their product of four heavy metals: lead, mercury, arsenic and cadmium.

Even low levels of exposure to these compounds can cause serious and often irreversible damage to young children’s brain development.

The change, required under a California law

passed by the Legislature in 2023, will affect consumers nationwide. Because companies are unlikely to create separate packaging for the California market, QR codes are likely to be present on products sold across the country, and consumers everywhere will be able to view [See Baby food, A10]

Smoldering Chiquita Canyon Landfill stops accepting trash

Operator tells L.A. County the site won’t take more solid waste. But chemical reaction is likely to continue.

By TONY BRISCOE

Unable to extinguish a smoldering chemical reaction that sent noxious odors into area neighborhoods and triggered legal action by Los Angeles County, the owners of Chiquita Canyon Landfill announced Tuesday that they would shut down the 52-year-old municipal waste site on New Year’s Day.

In a letter to California environmental regulators and public officials, a representative from Texas-based Waste Connections Inc. said that Dec. 31 was the final day it would accept solid waste at the 639-acre facility in the Santa Clarita Valley.

“Chiquita had wished to

maintain its crucial role in the community’s solid waste management system, but has made the difficult decision to close its active waste disposal operations,” wrote Steve Cassulo, the landfill’s manager. “Although Chiquita has available [capacity], due to the regulatory environment, maintaining ongoing operations at Chiquita is no longer economically viable.”

For nearly two years, Chiquita Canyon had been struggling to handle the fallout from a rare chemical reaction that caused broiling temperatures to break out deep underground in a closed portion of the landfill. The extreme heat roasted decades-old garbage and damaged the landfill’s gas control systems, causing foul-smelling gases to drift into nearby Val Verde and Castaic.

The smoldering conditions also caused pressure to build, resulting in geysers of hazardous liquid waste [See Waste, A10]

Powerless in Puerto Rico

Most of the island territory spends New Year’s Eve in the dark after an underground line failure. NATION, A5

New California laws to know

Measures that take effect this year cover cannabis cafes, AI, pocketbook issues and more. CALIFORNIA, B1

‘Nightmare’ convict charged

Two Bay Area cold cases are linked to Matthew Muller of Netflix docuseries infamy. CALIFORNIA, B1

Weather

Sunny and warmer. L.A. Basin: 74/49. B6

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